

Promoting Tourism Destination Image

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Abstract

This paper examines the role of tourism promotion as a component of destination image formation. It reports the findings of a study in which 1,100 respondents, from across the globe, described their pre-visit perceived image of seven sample destinations, as well as the information sources they used. The findings suggest that tourism promotion does not have a major impact upon the perceptions of travelers; and that other sources of information have a much greater bearing on the formation of destination image. As a result, tourism authorities need to understand that successful tourism promotion is dependent on a broad range of external influences. At the same time, the impact of marketing communication decisions on measurables such as revenue, market share, and costs must be carefully assessed.

Keywords: Tourism Promotion, Destination Image, Information Sources.

The formation of image has been described by Reynolds (1965: p. 69) as the development of a mental construct based upon a few impressions chosen from a flood of information. In the case of destination image, this 'flood of information' has many sources including promotion (advertising and brochures), the opinions of others (family/friends, travel agents), media reporting (newspapers, magazines, television news reporting and documentaries) and popular culture (motion pictures, literature). "Furthermore, by actually visiting the destination, the image will be affected and modified based upon first hand information and experience" (Echtner & Ritchie 2003: p. 38).

As Reynolds (1965: p. 70) states: "often, of course, the word 'image' is used as equivalent to reputation . . . , what people believe about a person or an institution, *versus* character, what the person or institution actually is". The latter could also be referred to as identity. With regard to experiential products like travel and tourism, consumers are involved in an ongoing search for information (Leemans 1994: p. 23). By collecting all of this information, the consumer creates an image or 'mental prototype' (Tapachai & Waryszak 2000: p. 37) which represents the travel experience. As tourism services are intangible, images become more important than reality (Gallarza et al. 2002: p. 57); and the tourism destination images projected in information space will greatly influence the destination images as perceived by consumers. The latter are generally accepted (Echtner & Ritchie 1993: p. 4; Padgett & Allen 1997: p. 50; Tapachai & Waryszak 2000: p. 38) to be based on attributes, functional consequences, (or expected benefits) and the symbolic meanings or psychological characteristics which consumers associate with a specific destination (or service). As a consequence, projected images influence destination positioning and ultimately the tourist's buying behavior.

Tourism destinations use promotion and marketing communication strategy to influence destination image (Beerli & Martín 2004: p. 667; Fridgen 1984: p. 25-26; Gartner 1993).

Narratives and visuals, for example, are used to create meaning in the market, deploying media and information and communication technology as enablers (Magala 2001).

Destinations can influence image formation indirectly through secondary place interactions with consumers, i.e. “vicarious experiences” (Kim & Richardson 2003). These are facilitated by intermediaries and produced imagination, in for instance the media, literature, arts, as well as popular culture (e.g. motion pictures, TV-shows or music) (Cohen-Hattab & Kerber 2004). Fairweather and Swaffield (2002: p. 293) found that “destination image also sets up criteria for negative evaluation. The promotional image is largely skewed towards a set of favorable experiences. When visitors encounter settings or experiences that differ markedly from their expectations, their evaluations can be very negative”.

The actuality of tourism has been suggested as being less important than its expressive representations in that what is depicted or not in destination image advertising, and on whose authority it is selected, involves a more complex question of what comprises the destination and who has the power to define its identity” (Fesenmaier & MacKay 1996: p. 37). It seems that tourism promotion as part of the image building process does not stand alone; instead it is interdependent with many other available information sources that are often perceived to be biased in nature and influence both the decision making concerning projected as well as perceived images.

In order to clarify the relative position of promotion and its influence on destination image, this paper will first place promotion in a wider context; that of the tourism destination image formation model (Govers & Go 2004). The paper then illustrates the importance of promotion

in building perceived images based on a survey among 1,100 online respondents from across the globe. The study set out to assess not only the image of seven sample destinations, but also the respondents' information sources that these images were based upon. This makes it possible to assess the relative importance of tourism promotion within the totality of the image formation processes. The research objective of this paper can hence be stated as follows: to identify the relative importance of tourism promotion as an image formation agent.

The Tourism Destination Image Formation Model

In recent years, the body of literature on destination image has grown to a respectable size, with a thorough overview being provided by Gallarza et al. (2002) as well as Pike (2002) who reviewed 142 papers). However, as Baloglu and McCleary (1999: p. 869) suggest "most studies have largely focused on its static structure by examining the relationship between image and behavior", from a construct measurement perspective. Studies have concentrated on the relationship between destination image and a plethora of variables such as: destination preference and visitation intention; destination familiarity and the impact of previous visitation; tourists' geographical locations; trip purpose; situational or temporal influences; the image as projected by the destination; and tourists' sociodemographical variables.

"Little empirical research has focused on how image is actually formed...analyzing its dynamic nature by investigating the influences on its structure and formation..., especially in the absence of previous experience with a destination". (Baloglu & McCleary 1999)

Figure 1 therefore depicts the destination image formation model and subsequently identifies those elements that have a dynamic influence on how the perceived destination image is formulated in the mind of the consumer. This model provides the basis for the detailed deconstruction of the destination image paradigm. It is discussed in Govers & Go (2004) from a 3-TDS (Tourism Development Strategy, Tourism Delivery & Supply, and Tourism Demands Specification) gap perspectives (based on the idea of the 5-gap service quality analysis model by Parasuraman et al. (1985: p. 44) and with major contributions from Baloglu and McCleary (1999), Fesenmaier and MacKay (1996) and Gartner (1993)).

Insert Figure 1.

To summarize, firstly, any destination image or tourism promotion projected by the local tourism industry, should be anchored to some extent on a true destination identity (Go et al. 2004; Noordman 2004: Chapter 8; Onians 1998; Van Rekom & Go 2003; Van Riel 1996: p. 34). This tourism development strategy formulates a tourism “product”, commercializing the offer using this identity and the authenticity of place (staged or real) (Cohen 1988; Cohen-Hattab & Kerber 2004; MacCannell 1973). It results in a projected tourism destination image, through the use of planned marketing and communication or vicarious experiences. Gartner (1993: p. 197-201) calls these “induced destination image formation agents” (“overt” and “covert”). The interactive nature of the Internet can add whole new dimensions to the possibilities of projecting these destination images. However, if the tourism product and the way it is communicated is not in line with the destination’s identity, it can create a Tourism Development Strategy gap.

Secondly, promotional images and secondary place interactions form the basis for a perceived destination image in the mind of the consumer prior to visit. This is mediated by the person's identity (i.e. self-congruity (Baloglu & McCleary 1999; MacKay & Fesenmaier 2000; Sirgy & Su 2000)), potential temporal environmental or situational influences (Gartner & Hunt 1987) (or Autonomous Agents according to Gartner (1993: p. 201-203)), and the direct or indirect interaction with other consumers (word of mouth/mouse (Riedl et al. 2002), or Solicited or Unsolicited Organic Agents in Gartner's terminology (1993: p. 203-204)). Such interactions result in knowledge about a particular destination and in turn, set the tourist's quality expectations. The level to which these expectations are met or exceeded during the actual tourism experience, is what is referred to as tourist satisfaction (Chon 1990; Govers & Go 1999). A second, Tourist Demands Specifications gap occurs in this respect when expectations are not met due to specified, but unrealistic tourist demands which are based on an idealistic perceived destination image. In this case, the actual tourism experience typically causes the perceived destination image to re-align with the perceived reality.

Another way in which tourists can become dissatisfied, is when the host and intermediaries do not perform according to their projected promise and the delivery of the product or service as well as the interaction with the host, is not in line with the tourist's realistic expectations (as influenced by tourism promotions). In this case, the tourism experience is not delivered according to appropriate standards and scripts. In such a case the perceived destination image will also be affected (through what Gartner (1993: p. 204-205) refers to as Organic Agents). More specifically, tourists will adjust their perceptions of places if what was experienced in consuming the tourism product, did not correspond to their perceived destination image, even if the latter turned out to be realistic. The lack of understanding of the experiential nature of tourism amongst the tourism industry decision makers (Gretzel & Fesenmaier 2003), can

easily lead to a mismatch in that, the way in which the tourism product is delivered is often not a true reflection of a destination's identity (or just a poor abstraction of all its multisensory, fantasy and emotive aspects) and it fails to incorporate the full potential of the prospective-rich tourism experience. This is where the Tourism Delivery and Supply gap can play an important role, because what is delivered in terms of product offering often tends to be different from the tourist's expectations that might have been falsely raised by tourism promotion.

The relative importance of tourism promotion among the other destination image formation agents is the central topic of this paper. The research questions are:

- What are the various information sources that consumers use to form destination images?;
- What is the relative importance of tourism promotion?; and
- Does the relative importance of tourism promotion vary among destinations?

The Survey

In October-November 2004, visitors to the virtual travel community Travellerspoint.com were able to participate in a research study measuring the destination image for seven sample destinations. Respondents were first asked to indicate which of the seven sample destinations they had not visited before and one of these was then subsequently randomly selected and inserted as Destination X in the following survey question (in other words, each respondent would provide feedback for just one destination they had never visited and respondents were 'assigned to destinations' randomly, although Dubai was oversampled). Respondents were asked the following two questions:

1. *Imagine that next week you will visit Destination X for the first time. Tell us your story.*

What do you think your experience in Destination X would be like? What images and thoughts immediately come to mind? What would you expect to see, or feel, hear, smell, taste there? Without any research or additional information, kindly be spontaneous and share with us whatever thoughts come to your mind right now, whether positive or negative. Make your response as detailed or as brief as you like, there are no limits, but try to write in story format; using complete sentences, not just loose words. If you know little about Destination X, your story will probably be short. If you already have clear ideas about Destination X, your story might be very long. But remember, there is no right, wrong or best model answer; simply express your own ideas about Destination X, and NOT what you think we want to hear. The content of your response will have NO impact whatsoever on your chance to win the grand prize. Share your ideas about Destination X with us right now, in the space below:

2. *The ideas that you presented in your story must have come from somewhere. From where? Please list your sources:*

Until recently, it would have been challenging to analyze the large quantity of qualitative data that this kind of approach generates, as the researcher would have had to process a daunting number of pages of qualitative text and code them. Then, to assure reliability of the results, at least two other researchers would have had to go through the same process, creating serious time and resource demands. However today, with computerized neural network content analysis software such as CATPAC, these types of constraints have been eliminated. CATPAC is a self-organizing artificial neural network software package used for content analysis of text. “CATPAC is able to identify the most important words in a text and

determine the patterns of similarity based on the way they are used in the text” (Woelfel 1998: p. 11). Summarizing, CATPAC identifies subtle and complex patterns in any documents or qualitative survey responses it processes and is therefore ideal for analyzing long pieces of text or high quantity qualitative data in order to identify the main concepts that authors of such text or respondents like to convey. It would go beyond the object of this paper to explain the detailed working of the program any further, as the above explanation is a simplification, but for a good overview please refer to (Woelfel & Stoyanoff 1993). Among others, Gretzel and Fesenmaier (2003) and Ryan (2000) have advocated CATPAC as being a valuable tool for content analysis in tourism research. For a complete description of the methodology, please refer to Govers (2005a; 2005b)..

Destination Selection

The selection of sampled destinations was the result of a combination of considerations. First of all, the study reported in this paper was part of a larger research project that included Dubai as the focus of study (Govers 2005a). Large scale ‘themed destinations’ such as Dubai intentionally leverage the ‘spectacular’ in their grand architecture and narrative, but lack semiotic expressiveness and ‘sense of place’. The ‘spectacular’-‘sense of place’ paradox is rather salient in the context of Dubai, especially when viewed against the backdrop of its Muslim-heritage (Govers & Go 2005). The selection for a particular narrative approach is significant because it can make the political economies of tourism policy and destination promotion strategy more visible (Govers 2005b). Several issues make perceived destination image and its consequences for tourism promotion of Dubai, a compelling and relevant topic, worthy of investigation, especially in the age when electronic channels of communication play a dominant role,

With Dubai being the central case study of the larger research project, some sample destinations were selected because of their resemblance to Dubai on one or more attributes. This was done in order to assess convergent and discriminant validity of the new methodology involved. Destination one, the Canary Islands compares to Dubai as an exotic sea, sun, sand destination. Destination two, Florida compares to Dubai in terms of being the entertainment capital in the region. Destination three, Singapore compares to Dubai as a rapidly developed city state and financial as well as a trade centre in the Orient, contrasting modernity with tradition. Destination four, Morocco compares to Dubai as a new exotic destination with Arabian heritage and expansive desert ecology. Finally destination five and six, Flanders and Wales could be positioned as complete opposites to Dubai, in terms of their characteristics as tourism destinations. In addition, several of the selected destinations have

been described as case studies in the literature on destination branding, such as: Florida, best practice (Ritchie & Ritchie 1998); Morocco, bad practice (Polunin 2002); Singapore, best practice (Ooi 2004); Spain (Canary Islands), best practice (Morgan & Pritchard 2004); and Wales, best practice (Pride 2004; Pritchard & Morgan 1998; Pritchard & Morgan 2001). This provided additional background information on the destinations involved.

Sample

In total 1,198 responses were collected. Most respondents reacted to e-mail newsletters sent out via Travellerspoint.com at first and later joined by MeetURplanet.com, and TrekShare.com, advertising the survey to the roughly 33,000 members of these three websites. This would indicate a response rate of 3.6%, although it is very difficult to be conclusive on that, as it is impossible to know exactly how many people read the newsletters and/or saw the additional banner-ads on the above websites as well as Mytripjournal.com and iTravelnet.com.

After an evaluation of data quality and cross-checking of completeness of answers were completed, 1,102 useable questionnaires were retained in the analysis. These provided a total of 111,000 words of destination image descriptions (For an average description of roughly 100 words per respondent, without any significant differences between destinations). The sample is split between Dubai (598), Flanders (142), Florida (94), Canary Islands (62), Morocco (68), Singapore (82) and Wales (55), according to the destinations on which respondents provided feedback. 54.7% of respondents is female. Based on country of residence the sample was subdivided according to world continent. This is depicted in the left hand column of Table 1.

Insert Table 1.

Respondents were also asked to indicate their country of origin or 'homeland' if different from the country of residence. 18% of respondents indicated a different country than their country of residence to consider their homeland. However, the migration between continents in the sample is limited to 12.8%. Major continental migration representing more than 1% of the sample involves Europeans and Asians that moved to North America; Asians and Australasians that moved to Europe; and North Americans and Europeans that moved to Asia. This is represented in the right hand column of Table 1. Of course if a respondent did not indicate a different 'homeland', the country of origin is equal to the country of residence.

The sample is highly educated with 80.7% of respondents holding a college or university degree or equivalent while 16.7% completed upper secondary senior high schooling. Also, this being an online study, it is not surprising that the sample is young, 53% being under the age of 30, 24% between 30 and 39 years old and 12% between 40 and 49 years of age. Obviously this sample is not representative for the world population or even the online world population. It needs to be emphasized though that this research did not intend to provide a globally representative description of the perceived image of the sample destinations and information sources used. Instead, it aimed to test an alternative, qualitative content analysis, methodology for assessing perceived image and subsequently identifying differences across destinations. Therefore, bias in sample selection was not perceived to be a major issue.

Results

Using the content analysis software, the totality of qualitative responses for each destination was processed in order to identify the most frequently used words to describe salient perceived image elements. For each destination, words were included in the analysis if they appeared in at least 10% of the responses, as presented in the list of most frequently used words produced by CATPAC. The results are listed in Appendix I and described in detail in Govers (2005a; 2005b). Respondents were also asked to indicate on what information sources their perceptions were based. This was done through an open question, the responses to which were analyzed in a similar manner as the image responses, using CATPAC. The most frequently mentioned sources of information, referred to by at least 3% of respondents (35 or more), are listed in Table 2. The middle column categorizes the information source according to Gartner's (1993) typology. This illustrates the importance of covert induced and autonomous agents – vicarious place experiences and temporal environmental and situations influences – through television, literature, internet, pictures and movies. 11 out of the 19 information sources listed in Table 2 include such agents. Television too, as a source of image construction also clearly occupies a dominant position, next to direct travel experiences (organic agents), which are the most valuable and richest sources of all.

Include Table 2.

In addition, Table 2 also emphasizes the great importance of solicited and unsolicited organic agents, i.e. word of mouth (mentioned by over a quarter of respondents) and word of mouse (the internet being in fifth place). Although this was an online research study, the internet does still not seem to occupy a dominant position, even though most respondents are active internet users (mostly members of virtual travel communities). However, the convergence of media and ICT will invalidate this point in future (Werthner & Klein 1999: p. 69). Pure overt

induced agents such as advertising only appear in sixteenth position, mentioned by just 4% of respondents. However, if television is ranked as information source number one, of course, the logical question to ask is to what extent advertising has been consumed as part of this vicarious place experience, without consciously registering it as such. Nevertheless, Table 2 seems to confirm all relationships predicted in the destination image formation model as described above.

The importance of the various information sources to the different sample destinations has also been assessed through analysis of variance. For each information source listed in Table 2, a dichotomous variable was created, indicating if a respondent mentioned the information source or not. These data were then treated as interval scale and analyzed using ANOVA. The results, which are striking in some cases, are reported in Table 3.

Insert Table 3.

The vital importance of vicarious place experiences, through television, movies and magazines is overwhelming in the case of Florida. In addition, news reporting is relatively important when referring to Florida, but this could be a confirmation of the transitory effects of autonomous agents such as the media coverage of hurricane Frances at the time that this research study took place. News reporting seems to be of little importance for Wales, whilst for Dubai, word of mouth appears to be of particular relevance as are the media in general to some extent. Movies have had their particular impact on the image of Morocco, but the top four information sources are remarkably less frequently mentioned in the case of Flanders. This seems to support the notion that the image of destination Flanders is less developed than for other destinations in this study. Again, these results seem to confirm the influence of all of

the various types of agents on the image formation process, but more importantly it emphasizes its dynamic and ephemeral nature and the relative insignificant impact of tourism promotion.

Discussion and conclusion

This paper provides initial confirmation that the various components in the bottom half of the destination image formation model, as depicted in Figure 1, do indeed have an influence on perceived destination image. Self congruity is then an important issue, as differences in perceived image across cultural groupings and gender classes are confirmed by Govers (2005a). Contrary to Beerli and Martín (2004), who focused on post-visit image, this study proves that secondary sources of information are essential agents influencing pre-visit image. Covertly induced and autonomous agents, in particular, have a dramatic influence, as they are mentioned in over sixty percent of the information sources in the study. Vicarious experiences, such as motion pictures, literature and television especially National Geographic Channel are mentioned by respondents. Autonomous agents such as, news papers, televised news and television in general; which represent the most important source of information; are also acknowledged by respondents and it can be therefore concluded that the media in general, have a primary influence in destination image formation. However, the role of internet was less important than was expected considering the population sampled. Nevertheless, as it is predicted that media and ICT will converge in the future (Werthner & Klein 1999: p. 69) both, it can be assumed will have a significant impact on image formation (Magala 2001).

At the same time, this study's findings support Beerli and Martín's (2004) conclusion that organic agents, i.e. primary sources of information, are essential as well. The second most relevant source of information that respondents refer to is their own travel experience or the experiences of others. Hence, also solicited and unsolicited agents, word-of-mouth, appear to be highly relevant and the influence that various image formation agents have on pre-visit perceived image also varies across destinations. Motion pictures have been mentioned specifically in relation to Morocco and Florida, where in the latter case, television in general is also an extremely relevant image formation agent. The case of Florida in particular, illustrates the ephemeral character of images and the dynamic influence that autonomous agents such as news reporting can have on the model. Solicited and unsolicited organic agents seem to be particularly significant with reference to Dubai.

The findings of this study indicate that the relative importance of overt induced agents such as tourism promotion seems to be limited. This is occasionally confirmed by the industry as well as can be seen in the media (e-tid 2002). According to a survey of British tourist boards the 'Queen Mother effect' boosted the number of visitors to the UK and helped counter-act memories of the foot and mouth crisis. The Telegraph (e-tid 2002) reported that the results of the survey by MICG, a London-based tourism conference organizer, suggested that the Queen Mother's funeral had more success than official marketing campaigns in encouraging visitors back to Britain. Bookings rose by nearly 20% in Cumbria, one of the areas worst hit by foot and mouth disease, while Cornwall showed a similar increase and many hotels reported occupancy levels close to pre-2001 rates. These examples illustrate how temporal environmental or situational influences can have a dramatic short term effect on perceived destination image. Some of these factors also have a longer term impact on destination image by changing a destination's identity and/or projected image.

The above findings allude to the importance of applying tourism promotion within the broader context of marketing communications. This would suggest that, promotion strategy is likely to result in limited impact if decision makers fail to comprehend that the choice of a tourism promotion strategy and its success is determined by numerous considerations.

Therefore, they should assess the impact of their promotional decisions on revenues, market share, costs and benefits within the realm of the various options, reasoning, and consequences of a destination's overall marketing communication strategy. In particular, decision makers should ensure that their integrated marketing communication strategy factors in covert induced agents and attempt to capitalize on temporal environmental and situational influences as well as vicarious place experiences (e.g. New Zealand and Lord of the Rings) or aim at reducing its potentially negative impacts (e.g. SARS, avian flu and terrorism).

Future research should therefore focus on direct cause and effect analyses of tourism promotions as part of integrated marketing communication efforts that attempt to influence pre-visit destination images of specific case destinations.

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Appendix I: Image descriptions for seven sample destinations

	% of 3,706 meaningful words	% of respondents
Dubai (n=598, words = 63,918)		
HOT (warm weather / heat / warm climate)	5.8%	28.6%
CULTURE (as in different, local culture)	5.4%	27.1%
HOTEL (famous / 7,6,5-star / luxury / expensive hotel)	6.0%	26.9%
BUILDING (as in amazing / special architecture / buildings)	5.6%	25.9%
DESERT	6.0%	25.4%
SHOP (shops / shopping)	5.5%	24.9%
ARAB (Arabic / Arabian)	5.4%	24.6%
MODERN	4.7%	23.7%
RICH (wealth / wealthy / rich)	4.6%	22.6%
NEVER (never been there / visited / heard of)	3.8%	21.1%
LUXURY (luxurious)	2.9%	15.9%
WOMAN (as in the position of women in Muslim / Arab countries)	3.5%	14.2%
SMELL (smell of spices / food / fragrances / heat)	2.8%	13.2%
WATER (water / sea)	2.5%	13.0%
MARKET(S)	2.3%	12.7%
BEACH(ES)	2.3%	11.5%
STREET (busy /lively / people in the street)	2.3%	11.0%
MUSLIM	2.5%	10.9%
SAND	2.2%	10.6%
OIL	1.8%	9.7%
CAMEL(S)	1.6%	9.2%
Canary Islands (n=62, words = 6,419)		
BEACH(ES)	12.1%	48.4%
ISLAND(S)	14.3%	38.7%
WATER (water / sea)	9.6%	32.3%
HOT (warm weather / heat / warm climate)	5.4%	25.8%
SUN (sunny / sunshine)	6.1%	24.2%
SPAIN (Spanish)	6.7%	22.6%
TOURIST (as in touristy)	4.8%	21.0%
HOTEL (comfortable / nice / good / luxurious / fancy hotel)	3.8%	17.7%
SAND	3.8%	16.1%
CULTURE (as in different, local culture)	3.2%	12.9%
BLUE (blue water/ skies)	2.9%	11.3%
NATURE (natural)	2.9%	9.7%
Flanders (n=142, words = 13,260)		
BELGIUM (Belgian)	20.1%	53.5%
BUILDING (old / historic buildings / architecture)	5.9%	22.5%
CHOCOLATE(S)	6.7%	21.8%
EUROPE (European)	3.9%	16.2%
CULTURE (as in different, local culture)	4.2%	15.5%
HISTORY (historic)	4.1%	15.5%
OLD (as in old town / buildings / castles)	4.4%	14.8%
STREET (cobble / narrow / winding streets)	4.2%	14.8%
FRENCH	4.5%	14.1%
NEVER (never been there / visited / heard of)	3.5%	14.1%
SHOP (shops / shopping)	4.1%	14.1%
BEER	3.5%	12.0%
CAFÉ(S)	2.6%	12.0%
FRIENDLY (as in friendly people)	2.7%	11.3%
Florida (n=94, words = 7,964)		
BEACH(ES)	16.7%	53.2%
HOT (warm weather / heat / warm climate)	9.7%	35.1%
SUN (sunny / sunshine)	8.6%	30.9%
DISNEY (Disneyland / Disneyworld)	6.6%	29.8%
MIAMI	7.7%	26.6%
AMERICA (American / Americans)	6.6%	25.5%
EVERGLADES	4.6%	21.3%
WATER (water / sea)	5.5%	21.3%

HURRICANE(S)	3.1%	14.9%
TOURIST (as in touristy)	3.3%	13.8%
NATURE (Natural)	2.4%	11.7%
PALM (Palm tree(s))	2.4%	11.7%
WHITE (white beach / houses / paving)	2.6%	11.7%
Wales (n=55, words = 4,811)	% of 236 meaningful words	% of respondents
GREEN	8.5%	32.7%
RAIN (rains / rainy)	7.6%	27.3%
HILLS	5.9%	25.5%
NATURE (natural)	7.2%	25.5%
PUB	6.4%	25.5%
CASTLE(S)	5.5%	21.8%
COUNTRYSIDE	5.5%	21.8%
NEVER (never been there / visited / heard of)	5.5%	21.8%
BUILDING (old / historic buildings / architecture)	5.5%	20.0%
FRIENDLY (friendly people)	4.7%	18.2%
VILLAGE(S)	4.7%	18.2%
OLD (as in old buildings / castles)	4.2%	16.4%
COLD (as in cold weather)	3.8%	14.5%
WALK (walking / long walks)	4.2%	14.5%
SHEEP	3.8%	12.7%
Morocco (n=68, words = 7,763)	% of 374 meaningful words	% of respondents
HOT (warm weather / heat / warm climate)	8.0%	32.4%
SMELL (smell of spices / food / fragrances / heat)	7.0%	32.4%
CULTURE (as in different, local culture)	6.7%	26.5%
SPICE (spices / spicy)	5.6%	26.5%
DESERT	5.6%	25.0%
COLOUR (colours / colourful)	4.8%	23.5%
BUILDING (old / beautiful buildings / architecture)	3.5%	17.6%
ARAB (Arabic / Arabian)	3.7%	16.2%
MARKET(S)	3.2%	16.2%
STREET (busy / lively / people in the street)	4.5%	16.2%
CASABLANCA	4.0%	14.7%
MUSLIM	3.5%	14.7%
AFRICA(N)	3.2%	13.2%
SUN (sunny / sunshine)	2.7%	13.2%
CAMEL(S)	2.9%	11.8%
TEA	3.2%	10.3%
Singapore (n=82, words = 8,298)	% of 401 meaningful words	% of respondents
MODERN	9.0%	31.7%
CULTURE (as in variety of local culture)	8.2%	30.5%
CLEAN	6.7%	29.3%
STREET (busy / lively / people in the street)	7.7%	26.8%
ASIA(N)	6.7%	25.6%
BUILDING (as in high-rise buildings / special architecture)	5.7%	24.4%
HOT (warm weather / heat / warm climate)	5.0%	18.3%
FRIENDLY (friendly people)	3.5%	17.1%
SMELL (smell of spices / food / fragrances / heat)	3.2%	15.9%
BUSY	3.0%	14.6%
DIFFERENT (as in different culturally)	4.0%	14.6%
SHOP (shops / shopping)	4.2%	14.6%
HOTEL (nice / luxurious hotels)	3.0%	13.4%
MIX (cultural mix)	4.2%	13.4%
AIRPORT (busy / clean / modern airport)	3.0%	12.2%
CHINESE	3.5%	12.2%
COLOUR (colours / colourful)	2.7%	12.2%
EAST (as in Orient)	2.7%	11.0%
EXOTIC	2.7%	11.0%

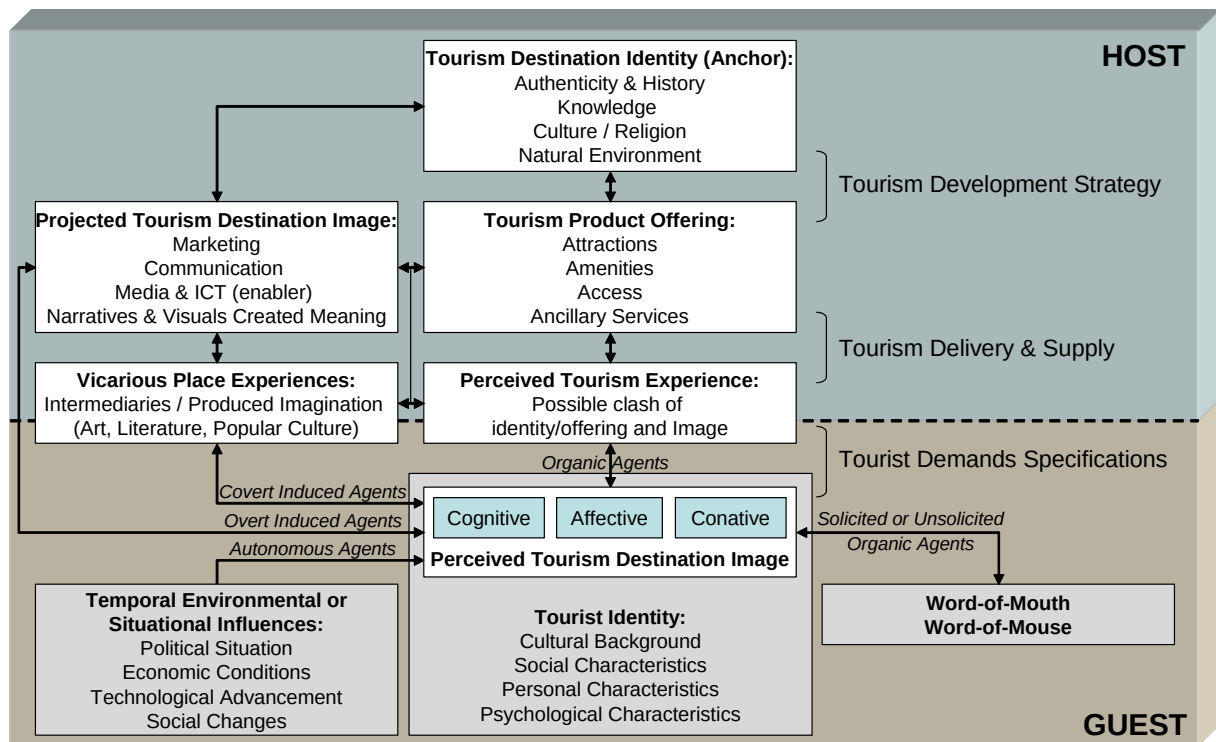


Figure 1: The 3-gap Tourism Destination Image Formation Model

Table 1: Sample across continents

	Residency	Cultural background
Europe	39.5%	37.9%
North America	26.5%	26.0%
Asia	13.9%	14.1%
Australasia	11.2%	12.6%
Africa	6.3%	6.6%
Middle- and South America	2.6%	2.7%

Table 2: Information sources

	<i>Agents</i>	Mentioned by
Television	Covert Induced & Autonomous	23.5%
Travel (elsewhere / in region)	Organic	23.0%
Friends	Solicited & Unsolicited Organic	19.1%
Magazines	Covert Induced & Autonomous	13.4%
Internet	Covert Induced, Autonomous & Organic	8.4%
Books	Covert Induced & Autonomous	8.1%
Pictures	Covert Induced & Autonomous	7.9%
People (other people)	Solicited & Unsolicited Organic	7.4%
Movies	Covert Induced & Autonomous	6.9%
Stories	Covert Induced & Autonomous	6.6%
Experience	Organic	5.8%
News	Autonomous	5.7%
Imagination	Organic	5.4%
Newspaper	Autonomous	4.5%
National Geographic Channel	Covert Induced & Autonomous	4.2%
Advertisements	Overt Induced	4.0%
Articles	Covert Induced & Autonomous	3.8%
Media	Covert Induced & Autonomous	3.7%
Documentaries	Covert Induced & Autonomous	3.5%

Table 3: Information sources for each of seven sample destinations

	<i>Dubai</i>	<i>Flanders</i>	<i>Florida</i>	<i>Canary</i>	<i>Morocco</i>	<i>Singapore</i>	<i>Wales</i>	<i>F</i>	<i>p</i>
Television	24.1% ^c	8.5% ^a	52.1% ^d	8.1% ^a	16.2% ^b	26.8% ^c	29.1% ^c	12.85	0.00
Travel	23.9%	14.8%	21.3%	24.2%	27.9%	26.8%	23.6%	1.26	0.28
Friends	24.2% ^c	6.3% ^a	13.8% ^b	19.4% ^b	17.6% ^b	14.6% ^b	12.7% ^b	5.03	0.00
Magazines	15.1% ^c	2.8% ^a	24.5% ^d	6.5% ^b	10.3% ^b	15.9% ^c	10.9% ^b	4.93	0.00
Internet	10.0%	6.3%	7.4%	8.1%	5.9%	4.9%	5.5%	0.92	0.48
Books	7.4%	7.0%	12.8%	1.6%	11.8%	9.8%	10.9%	1.51	0.17
Pictures	8.2%	5.6%	8.5%	3.2%	4.4%	14.6%	9.1%	1.56	0.16
People	6.0%	5.6%	8.5%	14.5%	7.4%	11.0%	10.9%	1.61	0.14
Movies	4.3% ^a	4.9% ^a	19.1% ^d	3.2% ^a	16.2% ^c	7.3% ^a	10.9% ^b	6.99	0.00
Stories	5.5%	7.0%	5.3%	11.3%	5.9%	9.8%	10.9%	1.11	0.36
Experience	4.8%	9.9%	1.1%	9.7%	4.4%	9.8%	5.5%	2.25	0.04
News	7.0% ^b	2.1% ^a	12.8% ^c	1.6% ^a	1.5% ^a	4.9% ^a	0.0% ^a	3.65	0.00
Imagination	5.0%	7.0%	2.1%	8.1%	4.4%	7.3%	7.3%	0.80	0.57
Newspaper	5.2%	2.8%	7.4%	3.2%	2.9%	3.7%	1.8%	0.85	0.53
NGC	3.5%	3.5%	5.3%	6.5%	8.8%	3.7%	3.6%	0.95	0.46
Advertisements	5.7%	0.0%	2.1%	3.2%	2.9%	1.2%	5.5%	2.26	0.04
Articles	5.7%	0.0%	2.1%	3.2%	2.9%	1.2%	5.5%	1.20	0.30
Media	5.7%	0.7%	3.2%	0.0%	1.5%	0.0%	3.6%	2.80	0.01
Documentaries	4.7%	2.8%	4.3%	0.0%	0.0%	2.4%	1.8%	1.36	0.23

Note: Rows that contain significant variance between groups according to ANOVA's F-test are indicated in bold. In those cases, means with a different superscripted letter (^{a, b, c, d}) are significantly different at the .05 level according to Duncan's post hoc test, while the letters indicate a within-row ranking (^a are groups with the lowest means, ^d are groups with the highest means).